the movies and had won several small parts while singing at night with a band at the Biltmore. I sent a note to her backstage, and she joined me for dinner between her floor shows.

Joy was a pretty, dark-haired woman with a sweet quality that hadn't been spoiled by her brief exposure to show business. I was looking forward to a pleasant dinner with an attractive girl and I had planned on bringing her up to date on the latest gossip from Des Moines. But my head was still filled with the sights and sounds of my visit to the studio that day. Seeing the actors, the cameras, the lights, and the scenery had only whetted my appetite to be a member of the club. I was starry-eyed and confessed to Joy how much I'd always had a secret yearning to be an actor.

"Take off your glasses," she said.

Studios, Joy added, as if to paraphrase Dorothy Parker, don't make passes at actors who wear glasses. If I wanted to break into the movies, she said the first thing I had to do was "Get rid of those glasses."

Joy said she knew an agent who might be willing to tell me if I had any realistic chances of making it in Hollywood—and be truthful with me if he thought I was wasting my time.

At promptly ten o'clock the next morning, I looked across a big desk at a skin-colored blur, agent Bill Meiklejohn, while trying to project "star quality" (whatever that was).

I'd taken Joy's advice and not worn my glasses to the interview with Meiklejohn; as a result, I could hardly see him during one of the most important interviews of my life.

But, heart pounding and hopelessly nearsighted, I presented a somewhat exaggerated description of my qualifications for movie stardom.

After finishing my pitch, I asked Meiklejohn gingerly if he thought it would be worth it for me to knock on a few doors in Hollywood.